The **Emperor** and the **Peasant** Boy: Part 1

By Rosa Martinez

Early one morning, a lone traveler walked down a dusty road. He traveled through a region of what is now Mexico. It was in the days of the Aztec Empire, a long time ago. There was a chill in the morning air. The traveler pulled his serape, a colorful woolen shawl, over his shoulders. **A** Soon, he knew, the sun would warm up everything.

The road ran through a narrow valley between tall hills. Forests covered the hills' upper slopes, but the lower slopes were bare and brown. In the distance, the traveler could see the snow-capped peak of a tall volcano. He was fascinated by the puff of smoke coming from it.

As the traveler made his way through the valley, he noticed many details. Large boulders lay scattered in the dry grass of nearby fields. Every so often, the traveler passed a small house. It occurred to him that it would be difficult to farm this land. Life must be hard for the people who lived there. **B**

Around a bend in the road, the traveler came upon a young peasant boy. The boy was walking slowly through the field. He seemed to be searching for something. Every now and then he bent down to pick up a stick. The traveler guessed the boy was gathering firewood. **C** His family would use the firewood to cook their meals.

"Hello there," the traveler called to the boy.

"Hello," the peasant boy replied, looking up. The traveler gazed at a tiny, red adobe hut set back from the road. There was a lemon tree next to the hut, and a small field of dry-looking corn nearby. It was clear that the people who lived there were poor. **D** They must have learned to be quite thrifty in order to live on what little they had.

Word definitions, if needed

traveler = someone who goes from one place to another

region = an area

Aztec Empire

serape = a colorful woolen shawl or blanket

valley = the low part between mountains or hills

slopes = sides of a mountain

bare = without plants

volcano = a mountain with a hole in the top or side that sends out rocks, ash, or lava

fascinated = very interested

details = small things

boulders = big rocks

scattered = all around

It occurred to him = he figured out

bend = turn

firewood = wood used to make a fire

gazed = stared

red adobe hut = a building made from clay dried by the sun

thrifty = careful about saving

"Do you live in that house over there?" the traveler asked the boy, pointing to the hut.

"Yes," said the boy. "I live with my mama and papa." The boy stared at the stranger. Strangers seldom passed this way. Still, the man seemed harmless enough. So the boy went back to searching for sticks. **E**

seldom = not very often
passed this way = came there
harmless enough = not dangerous

Say to the students: **Next time, we'll read Part 2. What do you think will happen next?**

(Allow students to make predictions if time allows.)

The Emperor and the Peasant Boy: Part 2

By Rosa Martinez

Word definitions, if needed

The traveler continued to watch the boy gathering firewood. He knew that the boy's family had to work hard to put food on the table. He looked at the handful of small sticks and twigs the boy was holding.

put food on the table = have enough to eat

"I can see that it is not easy to find wood in this field. There must be plenty of wood up in the forest on the hillsides," the traveler said. "You should collect your wood up there." **A**

"Oh no!" the peasant boy exclaimed, as though shocked at the suggestion. "That is not possible!"

"Why not?" asked the traveler. "Isn't life hard enough without making it even harder?"

"All of that land in the forest belongs to the emperor," said the boy. "We have heard that he goes hunting there several times a year. The emperor's law says that no one else may enter the forest. If I got caught up there, I would have to pay with my life!" **B** The boy turned away and continued looking for sticks.

pay with my life = be killed for doing it

"Listen," said the traveler, "There's nobody here now except you and me. You could go into the forest, and no one would find out. I certainly wouldn't tell anyone. You wouldn't get into trouble." **C**

"No thanks," the peasant boy said. "I'll just collect the sticks I can find in this field." He wondered why the stranger would suggest such a **roguish** idea. **D**

"What a shame," the traveler said. "All that good wood up there going to waste. Your emperor must be a selfish ruler to be unwilling to share his wood." He shook his head, as if to show that such behavior was hard to understand.

selfish = thinking only of yourself
be unwilling to = not want to

The peasant boy looked at the man's face. He thought he saw a rascally look in the man's eyes. The boy did not wish to hear any more daring ideas. He said, "The emperor may not be a **generous** person, but that doesn't mean I should break the law. My mother always says, "**Two wrongs don't make a right**." **E**

rascally = playful, mischievous

daring = dangerous

The traveler shrugged. He said, "Well, have it your way." He turned and looked down the road toward the distant volcano.

"Now," he went on, "I must be on my way. I have a long way to go before dark. Good luck, young man."

distant = far

Say to the students: **Next time, we'll read Part 3. What do you think will happen next?**

(Allow students to make predictions if time allows.)

The Emperor and the Peasant Boy: Part 3

By Rosa Martinez

Word definitions, if needed

The peasant boy said good-bye to the stranger and went back to collecting wood. By late afternoon, he had gathered a large bundle. If they were thrifty with the wood, his family would have enough for a week.

bundle = a group of things tied together
thrifty = careful about saving

Several days later, another stranger arrived at the red adobe hut. He said he was a messenger from the emperor. The boy and his family were ordered to leave the next morning and return with the stranger to the emperor's palace. They shared their dinner with the messenger. Then they made a space for him to sleep on some blankets on the floor.

messenger= someone who delivers a message or information

The next morning, they all set out for the emperor's palace. The peasant family walked along the road in silence. They were afraid they might be in some kind of trouble. **A** When they arrived at the palace, they were led into the royal throne room. The emperor was sitting on his throne, waiting for them.

throne room = room where the emperor sits

The peasant boy looked around the throne room, fascinated by everything he saw. Then he looked at the emperor, who was dressed in his royal garments. When he saw the emperor's face, his eyes grew wide and his jaw dropped. He recognized the man with the rascally look in his eyes!

garments = clothes
eyes grew wide
jaw dropped
recognized = remembered seeing before
rascally = playful, mischievous

"You're the stranger—the man who I met on the road," the boy gasped. **B** He paused to catch his breath. "You told me to steal the wood from the emperor's forest!" A wave of fear swept over him.

The emperor smiled at the boy and his family. "There is nothing to be afraid of," he said. "I often **disguise** myself and wander about the empire alone. This way I learn about my subjects. I can find out whether there is anything I can do to help my people." **C**

subjects = people who live in his kingdom/empire

Looking directly at the boy, the emperor went on, "I am proud to have such honest and **loyal** subjects. You refused to break my laws. For that, I intend to reward you and your family. This chest of gold is yours." **D**

The peasant boy and his parents were about to thank their emperor for his generous gift, but the emperor stopped them. "There is one more thing," he said. "Thanks to you, I have learned that one of my laws is **unjust**. From now on, all who wish to enter my forests may do so. **E** Now I invite you to dine with the emperor. Tonight you will stay in the palace as royal guests!"

intend = plan

dine = eat

Say to the students: **Did you like this story? Thumbs up if you liked it, down if you didn't like it.** *(Allow students to explain their opinion if time allows.)*